

OMISSION OF RELATIVE PRONOUNS



WHAT IS OMISSION?

- **Omission = leaving out a relative pronoun.**
- Sometimes we can remove:
 - **who**
 - **whom**
 - **which**
 - **that**



WHEN CAN WE OMIT?

- We can omit the relative pronoun when it is the **OBJECT** of the clause.
- **Examples:**
 - The man (**who/whom**) I saw yesterday was friendly.
 - The car (**that/which**) I bought is very fast.
 - The girl (**whom/that**) we invited came late.
 - The movie (**that/which**) we watched was exciting.



WHEN CANNOT WE OMIT?

- We **CANNOT** omit the pronoun when it is the **SUBJECT** of the clause.
- **Examples:**
 - The man **who robbed** the bank was arrested.
 - The girl **who sits** next to me is very smart.
 - The students **who study** hard get good grades.
 - The dog **that barked** all night was noisy.
- **Incorrect:**
 - The ~~man-robbed~~ the bank was arrested.
 - The ~~girl-sits~~ next to me is very smart.



EASY WAY TO CHECK

- **Ask:**

- “Does the clause already have a subject?”

- **Example:**

- The man **who I saw** yesterday is not here now.

- subject = I

- who = **object**

- can omit**

- **Example:**

- The man **who called me** yesterday is not here now.

- who = **subject**

- cannot omit**



USE OF “THAT”

- **After these words, we usually use THAT:**
 - all
 - everything
 - little
 - much
 - none
 - no
 - superlatives (best, biggest, most beautiful...)



EXAMPLES WITH “THAT”

- Everything **that** he said was true.
- All the books **that** I bought are useful.
- This is the **best** movie **that** I have ever seen.
- She told me **little** **that** was helpful.
- That is the **most** interesting story **that** I know.



RELATIVE PRONOUNS AFTER PREPOSITIONS

- When the **preposition** comes at the END,
- the **pronoun** can be omitted.
- **Examples:**
 - The man (**who/whom/that**) I spoke **to** was helpful.
 - The friend (**who/whom/that**) I traveled **with** speaks French.
 - The chair (**which/that**) I sat **on** was broken.
- **Omitted:**
 - The man **I spoke to** was helpful.
 - The friend **I traveled with** speaks French.
 - The chair **I sat on** was broken.



PREPOSITION BEFORE RELATIVE PRONOUN

- If the preposition comes **BEFORE** the pronoun:
- USE:
 - **whom**
 - **which**
- NOT:
 - **who**
 - **that**
- Because **who/that** cannot be omitted



EXAMPLES

- **Formal English:**

- The man **to whom I spoke** was helpful. ~~who~~
- The friend **with whom I traveled** spoke French. ~~who~~
- The chair **on which I sat** was uncomfortable. ~~that~~

- **Less Formal / Everyday English:**

- The man **I spoke to** was helpful.
- The friend **I traveled with** spoke French.
- The chair **I sat on** was uncomfortable.



QUICK SUMMARY

Situation	Omit?
Pronoun = object	 Yes
Pronoun = subject	 No
Preposition at end	 Yes
Preposition before pronoun	 No



PRACTICE

- Choose the correct answer.
 - The boy ____ called me is my cousin.
(a) who
(b) —
 - The car ____ I bought is expensive.
(a) that
(b) —
(c) both possible
 - The girl to ____ I spoke was polite.
(a) who
(b) whom
(c) that
 - This is the best cake ____ I have ever eaten.
(a) which
(b) that
 - The man ____ we met yesterday was friendly.
(a) whom
(b) —
(c) both possible
1. who
 2. both possible
 3. whom
 4. that
 5. both possible

